

Cultural Capsules

Three thematic packs – 30 conferences

Live one-hour conferences on French culture, delivered on Zoom by a bilingual signature speaker and followed by 15–20 minutes of questions. No French required, no prior knowledge assumed. Capsules are sold in packs of ten around a single theme, independently of the language courses.

Our purpose is to open a patrimoine of exceptional richness to those who already love it from a distance, and to make it genuinely legible. Each capsule begins with something the audience thinks it knows — the baguette, Chanel, Piaf — and works outward into the history and the sociology hiding behind the cliché. The method is the small story that carries the large one, les petites histoires qui font la grande Histoire: a salt tax that explains why butter is salted in Brittany, a laboratory sample number that becomes the world's best-selling perfume, a bitter French song about a couple falling out of love that Frank Sinatra turned into the American anthem of self-determination. Every subject is tied back to what binds France to the United States: the collectors, the soldiers, the films, the songs and the arguments the two countries have been sharing for two hundred years.

Pack 1 – Fashion & Art

French aesthetics – 10 Capsules

French elegance is not a gift of national temperament: it is a construction, mixing technical rigor with freedom of spirit. This pack shows taste being manufactured by a king, prised away from authority by artists, and finally handed to the street.

The pack runs from Versailles to the walls of the world. It opens with Louis XIV inventing fashion as an instrument of state, then follows the artists who freed beauty from authority — Monet freeing the eye, Rodin the body, Matisse colour. It arrives at the four couturiers who rebuilt the twentieth-century silhouette: Chanel, Dior, Saint Laurent, Givenchy. It closes with the two rebels who opened the doors — Gaultier, who let everyone onto the runway, and JR, who took art off the wall and pasted it onto the world.

Capsule 1 – Louis XIV

The revelation that opens the pack: fashion was not born by accident, it was a state economic strategy. Colbert, the silk of Lyon, the Gobelins, and a court where clothing was an instrument of power — a very "business" concept, and the moment the audience understands that French elegance began as industrial policy and soft power.

Capsule 2 – Claude Monet

The birth of individual liberty in art, far from the orders of the Académie and the Salon. Learn what Impressionism actually did to painting, why the name began as a critic's insult, and how America bought Monet before France had finished arguing about him.

Capsule 3 – Auguste Rodin

The transition to modern sculpture, where raw emotion displaces decoration: the scandal of his early work, The Thinker, The Kiss. The capsule confronts the shadow of the story — Camille Claudel, an artist of the first rank whose reputation is only now being restored.

Capsule 4 – Henri Matisse

The lesson of colour, and a solar, optimistic vision of France: the Fauve scandal, the discipline hidden behind the apparent joy, and the paper cut-outs invented from a wheelchair at the end of his life. The audience leaves with a working vocabulary for looking at modern painting.

Capsule 5 – Coco Chanel

The French self-made woman, and a comfort revolution that speaks directly to American pragmatism: jersey, the little black dress, No. 5, costume jewellery, the chain strap that freed women's hands. Learn how she built the persona of "Coco" — and face the documented shadow of the Occupation years.

Capsule 6 – Christian Dior

Resilience: how one collection, in February 1947, relaunched a ruined national industry and put a country back on its feet. Weigh the counter-argument that the New Look sent women back into the corset, and discover Catherine Dior, resistance fighter and the woman behind Miss Dior.

Capsule 7 – Yves Saint Laurent

The most "American" of the couturiers in his fight for the emancipation of women, and an intellectual of fashion: Le Smoking, the trench, the safari jacket, the invention of luxury ready-to-wear. Follow the collapse and the comeback, and the 1983 Met retrospective — the first the museum ever gave a living designer.

Capsule 8 – Hubert de Givenchy

The glamour subject par excellence, and the ideal emotional bridge to an American audience: a young couturier, an unknown actress named Audrey Hepburn, and a twenty-five-year alliance that turned Parisian couture into a global desire. Discover how a wardrobe builds a persona — and who really won the Oscar for Sabrina.

Capsule 9 – Jean-Paul Gaultier

A rebel, punk and inclusive France that breaks the sometimes rigid image of luxury: sailor stripes, men in skirts, and bodies of every age and size on the runway decades before anyone called it inclusion. Trace the self-taught outsider's route into couture, by way of the corset of the Blond Ambition tour.

Capsule 10 – JR

Proof that the France of today uses new technologies — paste-ups, social networks — to make social art: monumental portraits of ordinary people on favelas, borders, prisons and the pyramid of the Louvre. Discover participation as an artistic medium, and the questions it raises, through work that includes his project inside the abandoned hospital at Ellis Island.

Pack 2 – Gastronomy & Wine

Terroir on the plate – 10 Capsules

For the French, eating is a political, historical and identitarian act. A loaf is protected by decree, a cheese is a battlefield, a name is defended in court across five continents. The audience arrives expecting recipes and leaves with an argument about what a country chooses to protect.

The pack is built as a French meal and as a French history. It begins with the two staples the state has legislated over — bread and butter — then turns to the two products France defends against the world: camembert, fighting for raw milk, and champagne, fighting for its own name. It descends into the rarities and the arguments — the truffle, foie gras, snails and frogs — before rising into craft with the macaron and chocolate, and ends with a peasant vegetable stew that Pixar made famous.

Capsule 1 – The Baguette

Bread as a struggle against industrialisation: the Décret Pain defines by law what may be called bread made in the French tradition, and UNESCO listed the craft as intangible heritage in 2022. Understand why bread in France is not a commodity but a right protected by the state — and why Napoleon's soldiers never carried a baguette in their trousers.

Capsule 2 – Salted Butter

Regional specificity and the history of taxation: the gabelle, the salt tax from which Brittany was exempt, is the reason salted butter is Breton and sweet butter Norman. A slab of butter that ends at the French Revolution, and the proof that France is not a monolithic bloc.

Capsule 3 – Camembert

The clash of two food cultures in a small round box: raw milk against pasteurised, French insistence on flavour against the strict sanitary norms an American audience knows from the FDA. Follow the cheese from Normandy

farm to patriotic symbol of the Great War — and see why the founding story of Marie Harel cannot be confirmed by the archives.

Capsule 4 – Champagne

The protection of a name in the face of globalisation, and the clearest possible explanation of the AOC: the second fermentation, the winegrowers' riots of 1911, and the birth of the appellation system. Discover the invented quotation of Dom Pérignon, and the long argument with California over a word.

Capsule 5 – The Macaron

The bridge between history and modern marketing: from the convent macaron to the Parisian double-decker and the tea-room houses that turned a two-euro pastry into the most efficient piece of affordable luxury ever devised. Catherine de' Medici, it turns out, did not bring it in her luggage.

Capsule 6 – Snails & Frogs

The cultural dare, and the perfect entry into French audacity and anticonformism: why did a nation decide these two creatures were noble food? Follow the snail from Roman farms to Burgundian butter and the frog from monastic loophole to Lyonnais delicacy — and confront the ecological reality of a now largely imported trade.

Capsule 7 – Foie Gras

Contemporary ethical debate handled with nuance, alongside the claim of an intangible heritage protected by French law. The practice of gavage is laid out honestly, the producers' case and the welfare scientists' case are both presented — and no verdict is handed to the audience, who will recognise the argument from their own statute books.

Capsule 8 – Chocolate

Paris repositioned not as a producer of cacao but as the world capital of chocolate craft and design: follow the bean from the Spanish court to Bayonne, where Sephardic families established the first French chocolate trade, and on to the Parisian ateliers. The capsule closes on the supply chain as it actually is.

Capsule 9 – The Black Truffle

Mystery and elitism, and the reminder that French soil hides codified treasure: the diamond of Périgord cannot be reliably farmed, and production has collapsed from around a thousand tonnes a year to a fraction of that. Learn to tell the real thing from truffle oil that contains no truffle — and why the pig has been retired in favour of the dog.

Capsule 10 – Ratatouille

The Pixar link is the perfect entry point for showing that French haute cuisine draws its roots from peasant common sense. Follow a poor man's vegetable stew from the Provençal garden to Escoffier's codification and the modern chefs who rebuilt French cooking around vegetables.

Pack 3 – Cinema & Music

Screens and songs – 10 Capsules

French cinema and French song are two forms of popular literature: a country that gives its highest cultural status to the lyricist and the auteur, and that has spent a century exporting its faces, its stories and its melodies to America — often without America noticing where they came from.

The pack opens with the magician who invented the dream, Méliès, then follows the voices and faces that carried France to the world: Piaf, who turned tragedy into a universal language; Montand and Aznavour, two children of immigrants who conquered the music hall and then Hollywood; Bardot and the Nouvelle Vague, who rewrote the grammar of cinema; Gainsbourg, who made scandal an art form; Delon and Melville, whose cold minimalism American directors are still copying; the yéyé explosion of Johnny Hallyday and Françoise

Hardy; the fantasised Paris of Amélie Poulain; and, to close, the small circle of French composers who have been quietly winning Oscars for sixty years.

Capsule 1 – Georges Méliès — the magician of cinema

How a Belle Époque conjuror became the pioneer of special effects, turning the documentary novelty of early cinema into an art of illusion and dream. From the stage to the screen, the vanishing trick becomes the film trick — and then comes the fall: ruin, oblivion, a man selling toys in a railway station, and a resurrection that Hollywood itself would eventually celebrate.

Capsule 2 – Édith Piaf — the icon of resilience

A child of the Paris streets became an international star, transmuting personal tragedy and the tumult of History into a universal musical language. From a serial-novel childhood to the Occupation and the star factory, from the conquest of America to the loves, the losses and the final testament — with the manufactured legend of a birth under a streetlamp set gently aside.

Capsule 3 – Yves Montand — the singer-actor who conquered America

The extraordinary destiny of the son of Italian political refugees, who climbed to the summit of the French music hall before seducing Hollywood and becoming a leading figure of committed cinema. Signoret, the American call, the Marilyn scandal, and a redemption through political engagement.

Capsule 4 – Charles Aznavour — the patriarch of French song

Portrait of a methodical songwriter who overcame relentless criticism of his voice to build a monumental career, writing his songs as miniature screenplays. The child of stateless refugees becomes France itself: the long years in the wilderness, then Truffaut, then America, then the indestructible monument.

Capsule 5 – Brigitte Bardot & the Nouvelle Vague — freedom, filmed

A double revolution at the end of the 1950s: a new feminine myth emerges at the same moment as a band of young critics reinvents the grammar of cinema. The manufacture of French glamour, the shock of *And God Created Woman*, and a revolution made by a group of friends with hand-held cameras — the one that American cinema has been imitating ever since.

Capsule 6 – Serge Gainsbourg — the genius of provocation

How a failed painter, haunted by a complex about his own ugliness, turned his fractures into an aesthetic signature and then mastered the art of scandal to make himself a monument. Birkin, the worldwide scandal, and the deliberate fabrication of a posthumous myth — the craft celebrated, the darker sides not looked away from.

Capsule 7 – Alain Delon, Melville and the French polar

The rise of an icon of cold magnetism through the French crime cinema of the 1960s and 1970s, whose minimalist style still fascinates American directors. The face of the polar, the silence of *Le Samouraï* — and the mystery of a star who never truly went to Hollywood, and yet is everywhere in it.

Capsule 8 – Johnny Hallyday & Françoise Hardy — the yéyé explosion

The emergence of youth culture and the baby boom in France, told through two opposite figures: the rock animal and the melancholy icon, two children of the same Paris answering the same desire. Two careers, two faces of the yéyé years, the concert that alarmed the country, and the legacy of a generation that imported American rock and sent something new back.

Capsule 9 – Amélie Poulain, Yann Tiersen and the imaginary Paris

An exploration of the postcard Paris and the fantasised nostalgia born from a worldwide cinematic success that redefined the tourist imagination and restored the accordion to respectability. The fairy-tale Montmartre, the gamble of the casting, and the eternal return of a dreamed Paris — the one the audience is quietly hoping to visit.

Capsule 10 – Hollywood has a French accent

The story of the closed circle of French composers who, from Maurice Jarre to Alexandre Desplat, have seduced the Academy by bringing a singular musical sensibility to American cinema. The mystery of a music with no face, the parallel paths of Jarre and Michel Legrand, and a French Touch that is still winning Oscars today.